

THE RULES SHOULD BE MEMORISED

PRIOR TO WRITING ACADEMIC ESSAYS

Rule 01: Avoid using contractions or abbreviations. (Ex. Use *can not* instead of *can't*)

Avoid contracted auxiliary verbs and negatives. These are very common in informal speech and writing, but are considered inappropriate in academic writing.

Non-academic: I don't think that I'm working hard.

Academic: I do not think that I am working hard.

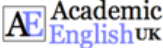
For example: *can't, couldn't, wouldn't, didn't, I'll, I've, I'd, won't*, etc...

Note that “cannot” is one word.

Do not use abbreviations or symbols.

Spell the words out. Ex: & = and; dept = department



NO Idiomatich / colloquial (slang) <i>Kids / boss / gonna / stuff</i>	NO number / bullet points	YES Passive structures <i>We analysed the data / The data was analysed</i>
NO Phrasal verbs <i>Go up / look up</i>	NO vague language <i>And so on.. / etc...</i>	YES –Academic Vocabulary <i>See A.W.L</i>
NO Personal Pronouns <i>I, we, In my opinion (limit use)</i>	NO Repetition <i>Constant repeating same words</i>	YES – Referencing systems
NO Contractions <i>It'll = it will / It's = it is</i>	Academic Style	YES Complex Grammar structures <i>Nominalisation / noun structures</i>
NO Questions <i>So why did the project fail?</i>	No basic language <i>Like – for example Thing – factor Lots of – significant amount Little/big – large Get - obtain Hard - difficult Good/bad – positive / negative Amazing / wonderful - important</i>	YES Caution / hedging – tentative language <i>Possibly / seems / appears / could / may</i>
NO Personal adverbs <i>Surprisingly / fortunately</i>		YES Accurate vocabulary <i>Difference between law / rule</i>
		YES Precise facts / figures <i>A few years ago / in 2014</i>
		

Rule 02: Use third person voice or impersonal language.

(Ex. *One can interpret...* instead of *You can interpret...*)

In other words, **the impersonal language** should be used. Most formal writing aims to establish an air of objectivity and impartiality, an air with which the personal pronouns *I*, *me*, and *my* seem inconsistent. In truth, objectivity results from proper use of evidence and logic rather than pronoun choices, but there is something to be said for *seeming* as well as *being* objective. Moreover, some professors prohibit their students from using first-person pronouns as a kind of discipline: many students do inject personal opinions and unexamined assumptions where persuasiveness demands objective evidence, and prohibiting personal pronouns seems to help curb this tendency.

The convention in much academic writing is to write with minimal reference to yourself as an author. The reason for this lies in a tradition of needing to present your work "objectively", as the work of a dispassionate and disinterested (that is, **unbiased**) researcher. So, one of the features of academic writing is a general absence of the first person pronoun "I". This can be difficult, as lecturers often say, "tell me what you think". Well, they do want to know what you think, but presented as a **rational, objective** argument. For this reason we also avoid using emotive language; instead we let the "facts" - or our reasoned argument - make the point for us.

It is important to note that while the avoidance of "I" has long been part of the academic tradition, these days some academics consider its use to be acceptable. So, you may encounter different views about the use of "I" over the course of your degree. In any case, you will need to develop the flexibility in your writing to play down the "personal element". Your lecturer, Cathi Lewis, for example, has stated that she prefers undergraduates to avoid the use of "I" in Introduction to Sociology (See the Lecturer's Advice section of this tutorial). Regardless of your

* Use a semicolon to connect the two sentences.

example: *I like to travel; specifically, I enjoy places with old cathedrals.*

* Use a comma before and after the transitional word/phrase in the middle of a clause.

example: *I like to travel, and, specifically, I enjoy places with old cathedrals.*

Some Common English Transition Words and Phrases

Adding Information	Examples
and not only . . . but also also moreover (more formal) furthermore (more formal) in addition (more formal)	We have seen the movie twice, and now we want to see it again. Not only did my brother break his leg, but he also bruised his rib. My friend speaks Korean and English. She also speaks Chinese. Cheating is dishonest. Moreover , it hinders students from learning. Students should be on time. Furthermore , they must be prepared. You must complete this essay by 5 p.m. In addition , you must do the exercises on page 47.
Giving Examples	Examples
for example for instance specifically in particular The first (second, another, etc.) example/reason is . . .	I have been to many countries. For example , I have been to Russia, Canada, Mexico, and Spain. He often eats strange foods. For instance , he once ate cow brains. I like to travel. Specifically , I enjoy places with old cathedrals. I love fruit. In particular , I like bananas, pineapple, and berries. My friend hates skiing for several reasons. The first reason is that she dislikes being cold. Another reason is that she often falls.
Showing a Contrast	Examples
but however	Bill earned an A on his essay, but Susan got a B. We wanted to leave at 8:00. However , Mike arrived too late.

on the other hand otherwise instead in contrast (more formal)	She hates housecleaning. On the other hand , she doesn't mind cooking. Students should attend class. Otherwise , they may lose their status. I am not going out tonight. Instead , I will stay home and watch a video. Women usually enjoy shopping. In contrast , men often dislike it.
Showing a Concession	Examples
yet nevertheless (more formal) even so however although even though despite the fact that . . . despite	He knows that he should do his homework, yet he never does it. I need to wear reading glasses. Nevertheless , I hate how I look in them. I know you don't like to study. Even so , you must pass your exam. There are many benefits to exercising. However , you must take some precautions to avoid injury. Even though the book is difficult to read, it is very interesting. Although the book is difficult to read, it is very interesting. Despite the fact that Kate is good at tennis, she lost the match. Despite Kate's skill at tennis, she lost the match.

Examples	Showing a Result
so she is very happy. ult, we could not go to the concert. ill. Therefore , he will not be here today. gainst the proposal. Thus , we must consider another idea. as in the oven. As a consequence , it burned. sequently, she could not drive home.	so as a result therefore thus (more formal) as a consequence consequently (more formal)
on high school. Likewise , it is hard in college. ch-reare and attention. Similarly , outdoor plants must be cared for uch practice and skill. In the same way , learning to write well practice.	likewise (more formal) similarly (more formal) in the same way
	Math was hard for me. Houseplants require m properly. Rock climbing takes m requires a great deal of
	Janet passed her exam. Tim was late. As a result James is not feeling we The committee voted a I forgot that the cake w Tina lost her keys. Con

Establishing Time Relation or Sequence	Examples	
first second finally in conclusion brother was watching television.	First , I think that she is studying hard. Second , I believe that she is a bright student. Finally , I know that she has great potential. In conclusion , I feel that she deserves to win the scholarship. In summary , we should offer her some financial help. in summary- meanwhile Jeff was working hard to clean the house. Meanwhile , his	
party. network. around. men to Africa. up on time. and money.	Showing a Condition	Examples
	or whether . . . or if . . . (then)	I must study hard, or I will fail my exam. Whether you are coming or not, I am still going to Amy's If you want to get good grades, then you must do your homework.
	Explaining or Emphasizing	Examples
	in fact actually in other words namely (more formal)	The bookstore sells cards. In fact , they have the best cards James is actually the first person I have known who has been late to class again. In other words , he didn't wake up on time. The plan needed only two things to succeed— namely , time and money.
	Giving an Alternative	Examples
	or either . . . or neither . . . nor (more formal)	We can go to the beach, or we can go to the mountains. You can either ride the bus or walk to my apartment. I like neither that person nor his brother.

A) Make it plural.

Sexist Language	Good Alternative
Give each student his paper	Give students their papers
as soon as he is finished	as soon as they are finished
The average student is worried about grades.	The average student is worried about his grade.

Usually Inappropriate	Good Alternatives
mankind	humanity, people, human beings
man's achievements	human achievements
man-made	synthetic, manufactured, machine-made
the common man	the average person, ordinary people
man the ship	staff the ship
six man-hours	six staff-hours
chairman	coordinator (of a committee or department), moderator (of a meeting), presiding officer, head, chair
businessman	business executive
fireman	firefighter
mailman	mailcarrier
steward and stewardess	flight attendant
policeman and policewoman	police officer
congressman	congressional representative

Rule 07: Avoid repetition.

Do not use the same word or the same sentence structure too frequently.

Repetition means that the same lexical item in several sentences subsequent to its first occurrence is repeated. For example, in this section, the phrase "lexical cohesion" is repeated more than twice. In addition, repetition helps to reinforce key ideas and new terms. However, the overuse of repetition in academic writing results in a text which sounds monotonous, i.e., it does not invite the reader to read it since it contains a lot of repetitions. This problem can be overcome by shifting the position of the repeated items in the sentence.

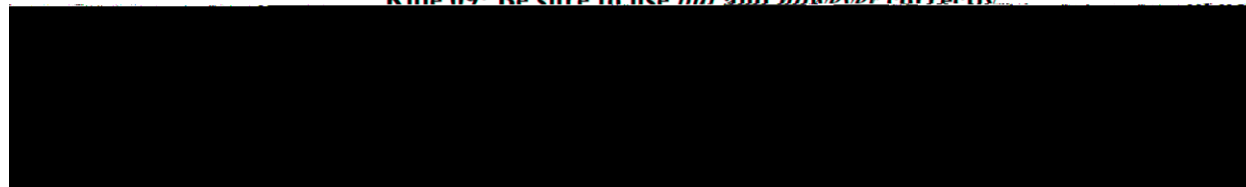
Use rich vocabulary: You have learned English for many years and this is the time to use what you know. Stay away from over-used adjectives such as "good" or "bad". Instead, use more dramatic, expressive words, such as excellent, wonderful, superb, or adverse, horrible, terrible, etc. Choose the more precise word over the more general one. This will make your language come alive, in speech or in writing, and get you higher marks.

Rule 08: Avoid using imperative language.

is rude (as do many of the
course, an occasional imperative

Use imperative voice sparingly in a scientific paper, because it comes across as sentences in what you are reading right now!). E.g. do not say "Recall that ...". Of course, using it in parentheses is not objectionable (e.g. "(see Walker 1996 for more details)").

Rule 09: Be sure to use *but* and *however* correctly.



Rule 19: Do not use personal examples





Rule 25: Do not tell short parts of the paragraph



Rule 28: Do not use ambiguous words.

For example: *this, these, his, it, they, there is, there are*, etc...

In written text, however, the intended meaning is quite often not evident to the reader, because there are many possible interpretations of "it" and "this".

Notes:

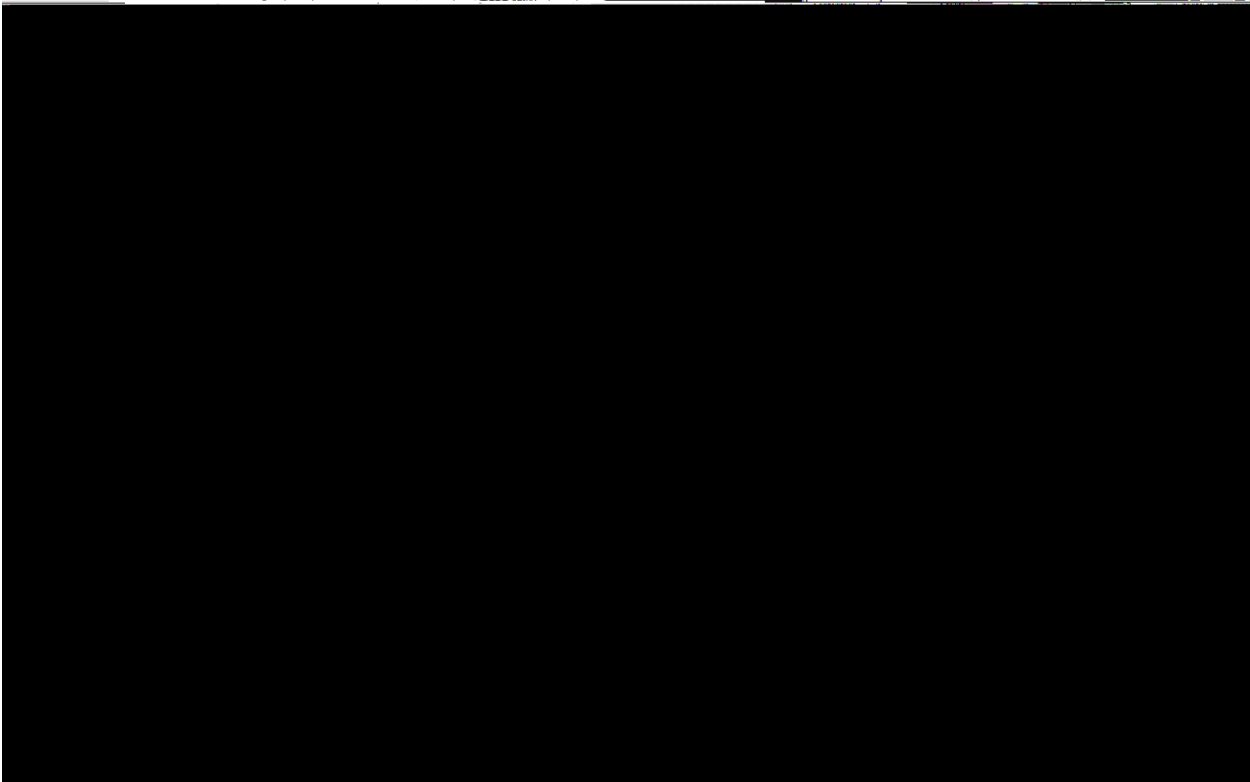
Rule 29: Do not ask rhetorical questions.

Readers want answers! So, instead of: "Do you know where the origin of tea is?" Write: "Tea originated in southern China near the border with India."

A rhetorical question is a question for which no answer is wanted. A rhetorical question is one in which the writer goes on to answer the question in the text where the writer assumes the reader knows the answer, or where the writer knows the answer to the question. Such questions are in essence statements for which no answer is needed. Your point being made could be more strongly and clearly expressed as a statement. You should not risk misunderstanding: make your point clear and 'up front'; for example:

Informal (includes rhetorical question)

Formal



Informal (includes run on)

Formal Alternative

Nurses must take into
consideration patients' dietary

Nurses must take into
consideration patients' dietary



Rule 34: Avoid words that do not change the meaning of the sentence.

Unnecessary words like "Actually", "Really" or "Basically" can be omitted.

write: He asked me if I would come.

For example, instead of writing: "Will you come?" You should

Rule 36: Do not use informal language

Formal: Whom did they elect?

Informal: Who did they elect?

an?

Formal - Use 'whom' as an object: Whom have they chosen for the position?

Formal : With whom did you study?

Informal : Who did you study with?

e. end of certain structures.

In informal language prepositions often come at the

Rule 37: Avoid using unnecessary words

Wordy phrases

1. it would appear that ...
2. with the exception of ...
3. in connection with ...

Using better English

1. apparently ...
2. except ...
3. about ...

of ...

5. most ...

5. a large majority

Rule 40: Do not start sentences with ‘And’, ‘Also’, ‘So’, ‘Or’, ‘Even so’, and ‘But’

Starting a sentence with them is sometimes considered inappropriate. A few decades ago it was considered totally unacceptable. Even today you can find several grammar books that advise against starting sentences with these conjunctions. However, the truth is that more and more academic writers now begin sentences with them. You must, however, make a conscious effort to avoid them just to be on the safe side.

Instead of these, use ‘In addition’, ‘However’, ‘Hence’, ‘Consequently’, ‘Alternatively’, ‘Nevertheless’ at the beginning of the sentence.

Rule 41: Do not use informal phrasal verbs

Rule 42: English text should be written in the active voice

Rule 44: Use 'One' and 'There' as a subject

e.g. 'There is a serious risk of...'

Some more phrases and their alternatives

- One could say that ... / Perhaps, ...

- One could draw the conclusion that ... / In conclusion, ...

As one might expect ... / Naturally, ...

possibility that / Possibly, ...

There is the po

no doubt that ... / I am sure ...

There can be n

e who maintain that ... / Some people say

There are thos

col of thoughts that ... / Some people say ...

There is a scho

Rule 48: Use some sort of “hedging” language and to qualify statements that you make.

HEDGING/AVOIDING COMMITMENT

et) such as *imagine, suggest, claim, suppose*

- use verbs (often with it as subje

apparently, arguably, ideally, strangely, unexpectedly.

- use 'attitudinal signals' such as

high 'soften' what you're saying.

- use verbs such as *would, could, may, might* w

a minority of a few *may* to avoid making overgeneralisations.

- use qualifying adverbs such as *some, several,*

Rule 40: Do not start a sentence with 'Therefore'

Instead, write, for example, "They, therefore, ..."